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COMPLETE GUIDE 05 OF 15

Replit Web and Mobile

A practical guide with steps, examples and a checklist. Read the chapter, then build the example.

BUILD APPS · COMPLETE GUIDE

Replit: build one app for the web and for a phone

Replit is a browser-based coding environment with an AI agent that writes, runs and deploys code for you. This guide builds one complete app, a study habit tracker, first as a website, then makes it work as a phone app. You need no local setup.

1. What you get in Replit

- **Workspace.** A code editor, a terminal and a live preview in the browser.
- **Agent.** Describe a feature in plain language; it edits files, runs the app and fixes errors. Read each change before you accept it.
- **Database and secrets.** Built-in options exist for storing data; API keys go in the Secrets panel, never in code.
- **Deployment.** One click publishes the app to a public address, with a custom domain on paid plans.

2. Plan the app before you prompt

Write the app on one page. Our example:

Item	Decision
Who uses it	A student, once a day
Core action	Tick off a habit for today; see the streak
Data	Habits: name, target days. Check-ins: habit, date
Screens	Today (list of habits with tick boxes); Habit editor; Weekly summary
Success	A student checks in every day for 14 days

3. Build the web app (step by step)

1. Create a new Repl with the web app template (React or a plain web template). Name it `habit-tracker`.
2. Prompt the agent, one feature at a time: *"Create a Today screen that lists habits from a local list, with a checkbox per habit. Ticking saves today's date for that habit."*
3. Next prompt: *"Add a form to create a habit with a name and a target of days per week. Store habits in the database."* Ask the agent to show you the table schema first.
4. Next prompt: *"Calculate the current streak for each habit: consecutive days ending today, skipping days before the habit started."* Then test it by hand: add three check-ins and confirm the number.
5. Ask for tests: *"Write unit tests for the streak function, including the case where a day is missing."* Run them in the Shell.
6. Click **Deploy**. Open the public link on your laptop and confirm the same data appears after a refresh.

```
// The streak rule, written so you can test it (ask the agent for this shape)
export function streak(checkins, today) {
  const days = new Set(checkins);              // ISO dates, e.g. "2026-11-09"
  let n = 0, d = new Date(today);
  while (days.has(d.toISOString().slice(0, 10))) { n++; d.setDate(d.getDate() - 1); }
  return n;
}
```

4. Make it a phone app

You have two routes. Choose by how much you need device features.

Route	How	When
A. Installable web app (fastest)	Add a web app manifest and a service worker. On a phone, open the link and choose *Add to Home Screen*.	Habit tracker, notes, forms, dashboards.
B. Native app with Expo (React Native)	Create an Expo project in Replit, preview on your phone with the Expo Go app, then build with EAS for the App Store or Play Store.	Push notifications, camera, offline-first use.

For Route A, prompt: "*Make this app installable: add a web app manifest with name, icon 512 by 512, theme colour, and display standalone. Add a service worker that caches the app shell so it opens offline.*" Test on your phone: open the link, then Add to Home Screen.

For Route B, start a new Expo template and prompt the agent to port the same screens and data functions. The streak function is plain JavaScript and moves over unchanged. Check Replit's and Expo's current documentation for the exact preview and build steps, because they change.

MOBILE REALITY CHECK

A phone app needs store accounts, a privacy policy and a support address before publishing. The web app route avoids this until you have users.

5. Keep secrets and data safe

- Add API keys in the Secrets panel. Check that `.env` files are not committed.
- Use the publishable key for the database in the browser; keep write rules strict.
- Ask the agent to validate every form input on the server, not only in the browser.

6. Common mistakes

- Prompting for the whole app at once. Build one feature, test it, then continue.
- Accepting code you have not read. Ask the agent to explain the change.
- Forgetting to test the deployed link, not only the preview.

7. Checklist

- Screens match the plan on paper.
- Streak tests pass; the deployed link works.
- Installable on a phone (Route A) or previewed in Expo Go (Route B).
- No secrets in code.

Replit's plans, mobile options and agent behaviour change often; check the current Replit documentation before you start.